

Review & Revision

CMSC839E: Uncertainty Communication for Decision-making

<https://fumeng-yang.github.io/CMSC839E>

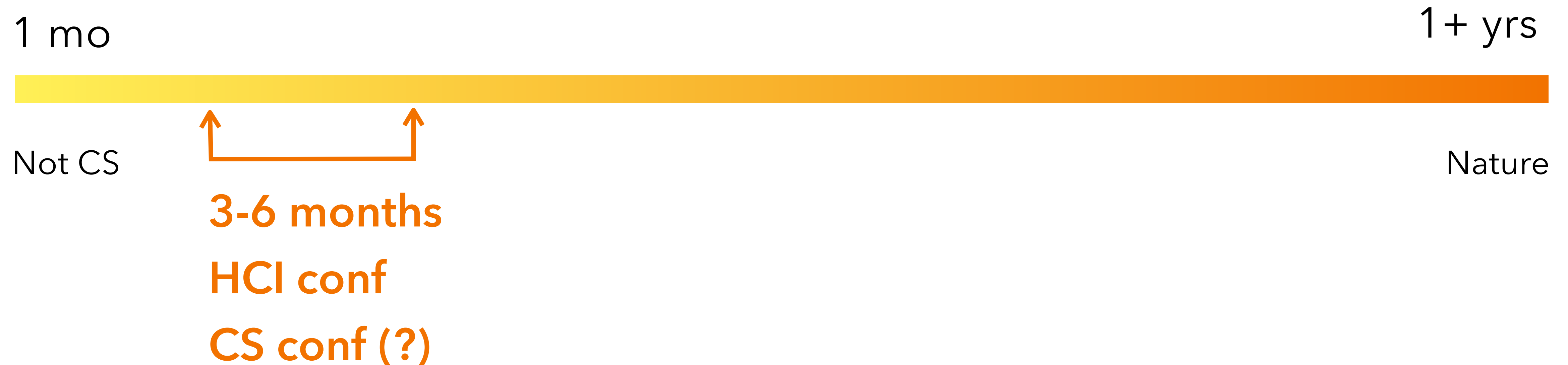
November 5, 2025 @ UMD by Fumeng Yang

Make the peer review
process **better**

Peer review

the system used to assess the quality of a manuscript before it is published

... also for authors to get feedback and improve their work

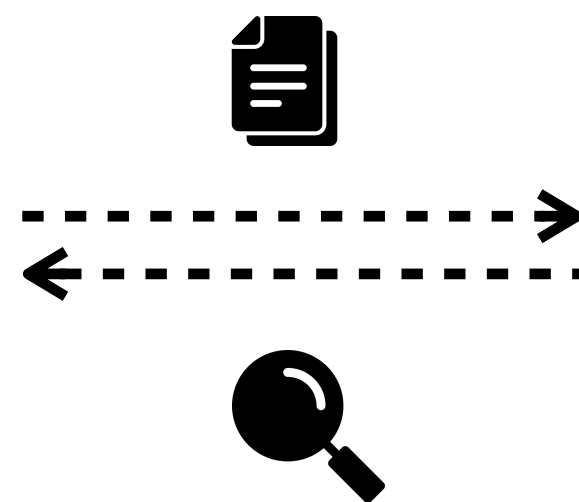
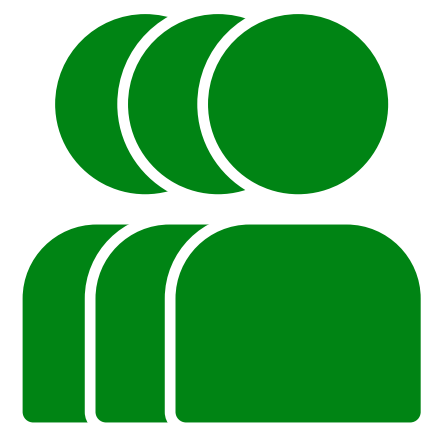


HCI conference review

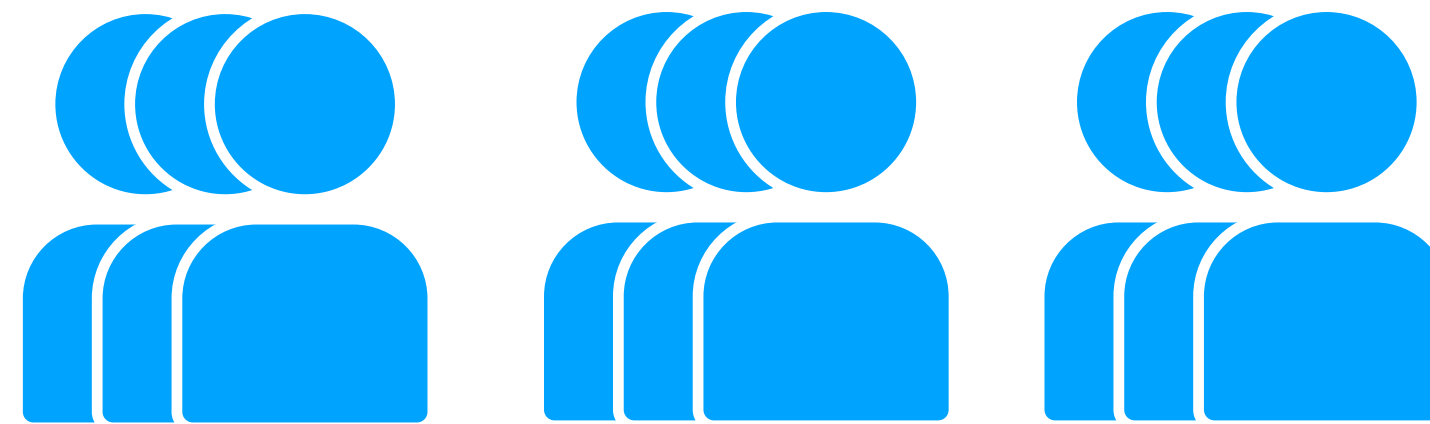
varies from conference to conference

→ direct comm
-----> indirect comm

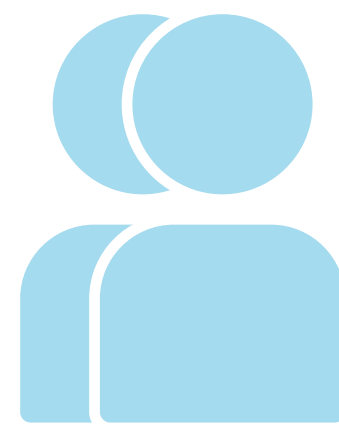
authors



2-3 program committees
or associated chairs

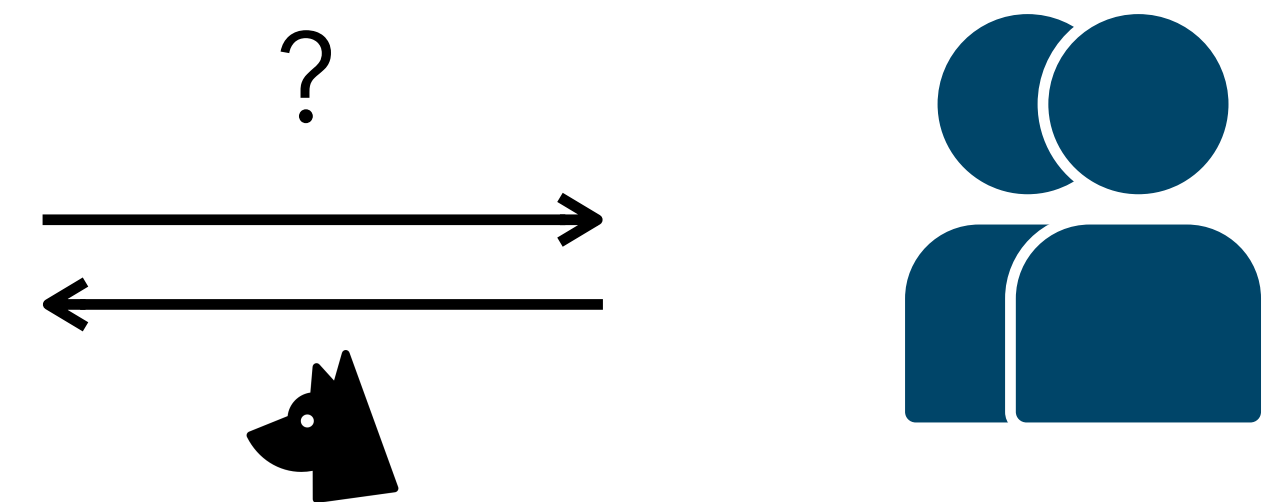


↑↓ invite

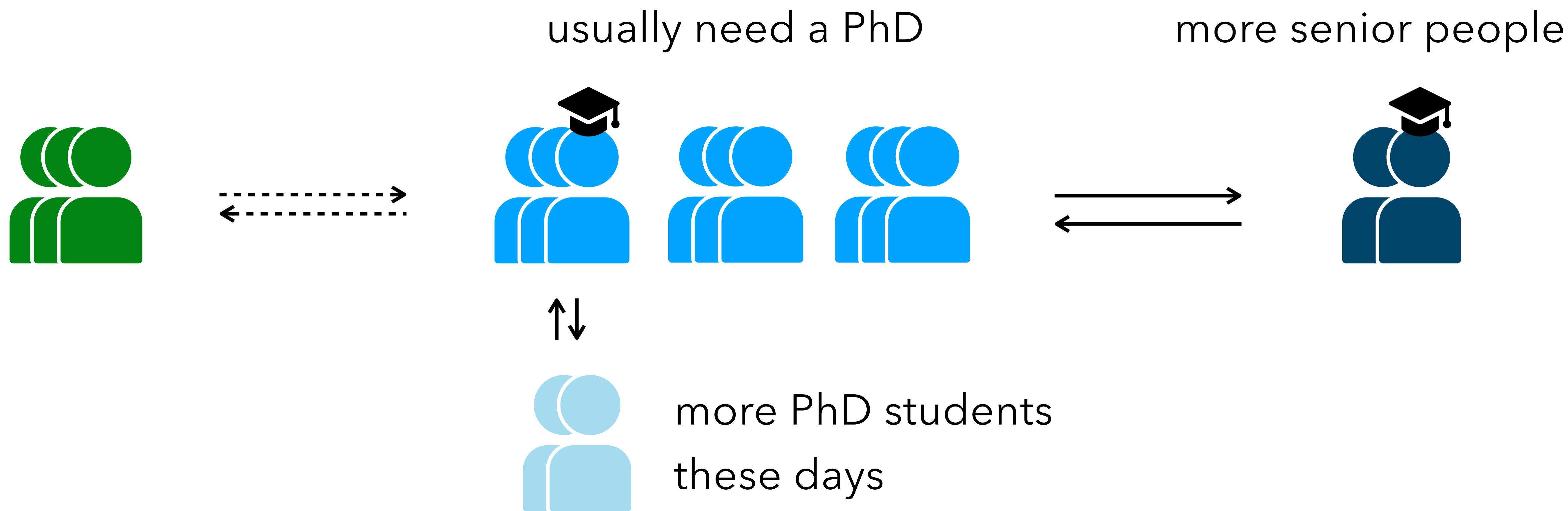


0-2 external reviewers

overall paper chairs,
paper chairs

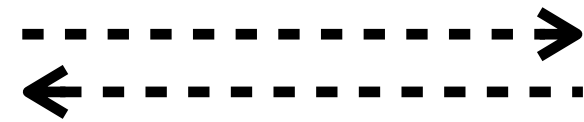
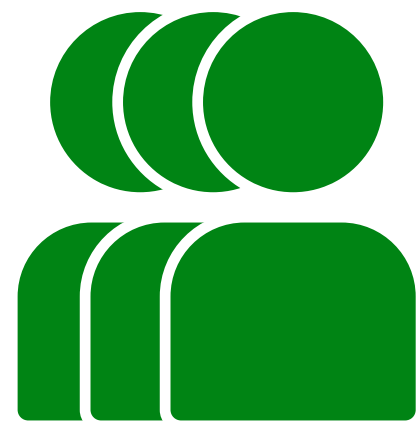


HCI conference review

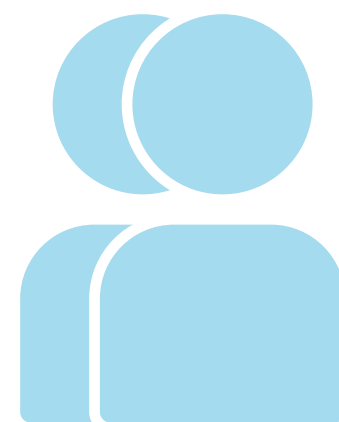
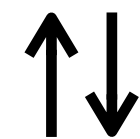
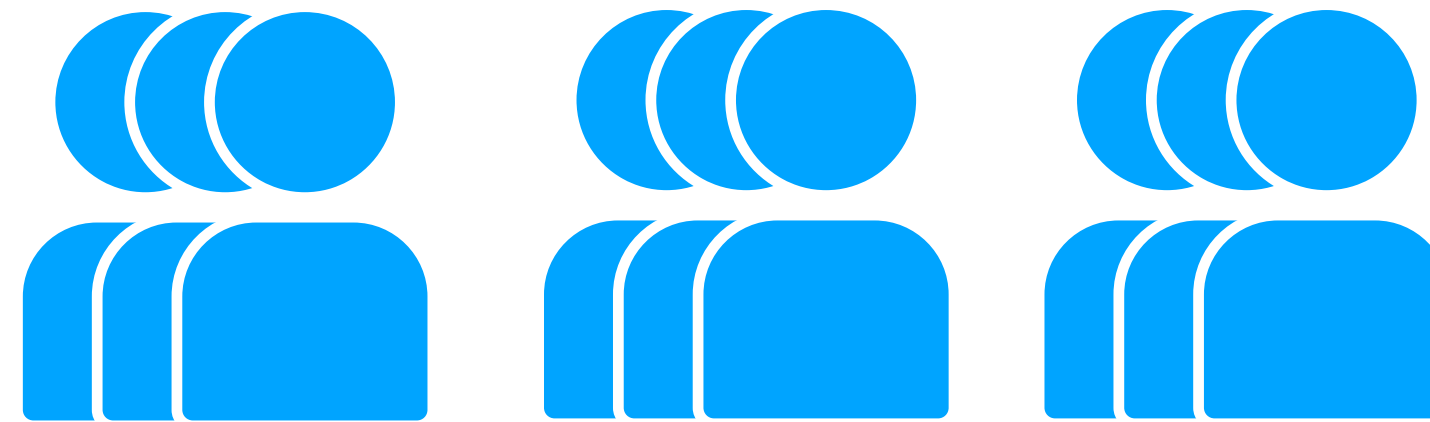


HCI conference review

Authors often don't know reviewers (single blind)

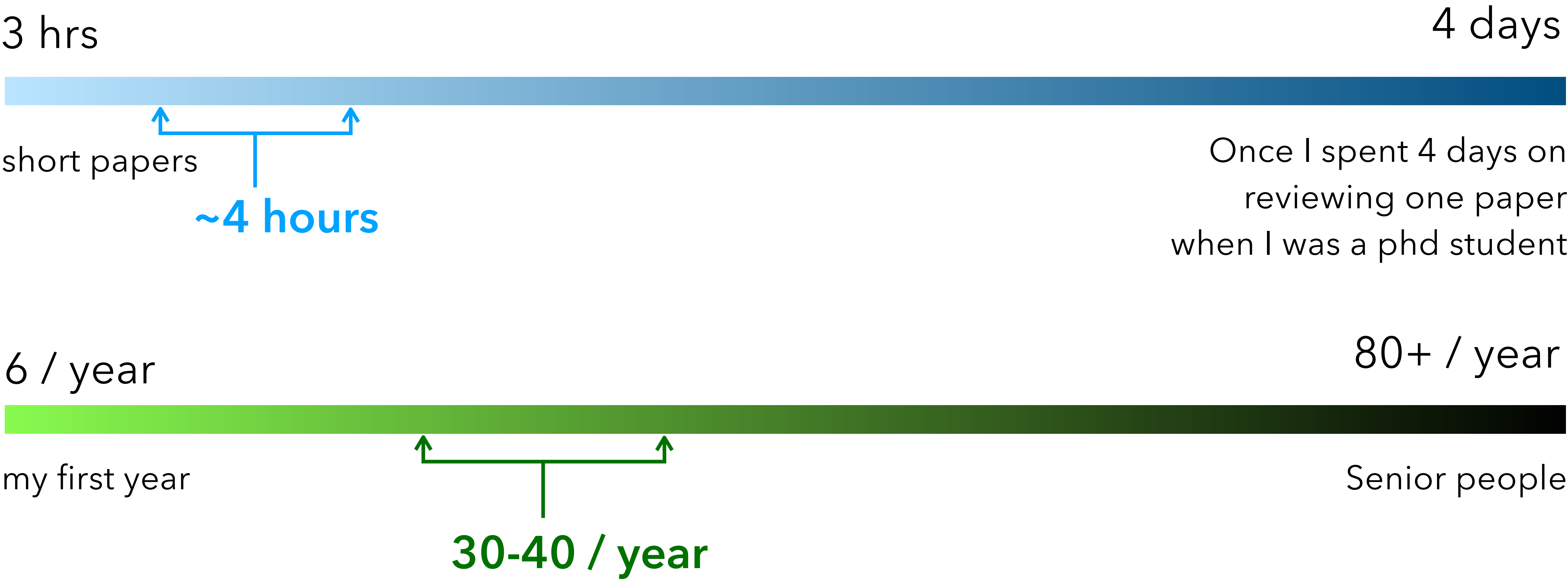


PCs/ACs *often* know authors and externals



If authors disclose their names
If authors choose not to do so
or rules (double blind)

Peer Review: A Flawed Process...?



The numbers will be different if you are in a different field.

Peer Review: A Flawed Process...?

Non-paid work

No review of review - so quality?

The small sample size / p dance - randomness

Miss critical information or have personal biases

Misconduct: reviewers steal authors' ideas, steal identities

Solution: Change the reviewing process?

Peer Review: A Flawed Process...?

- Non-paid work
 - No review of review - so quality?
 - The small sample size / p dance - randomness
 - Miss critical information or have personal biases
 - Misconduct: reviewers steal authors' ideas, steal identities
- As authors: Volunteer to review. e.g., each paper needs 3 reviews. Then the authors on this paper should review 3 others papers

Peer Review: A Flawed Process...?

- Non-paid work ← Incentives, e.g., "Special Recognitions for Outstanding Reviews", journal editors might be nicer to your submissions
- No review of review - so quality?
- The small sample size / p dance - randomness
- Miss critical information or have personal biases
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As authors:

Improve your mean

Reduce your SD

Peer Review: A Flawed

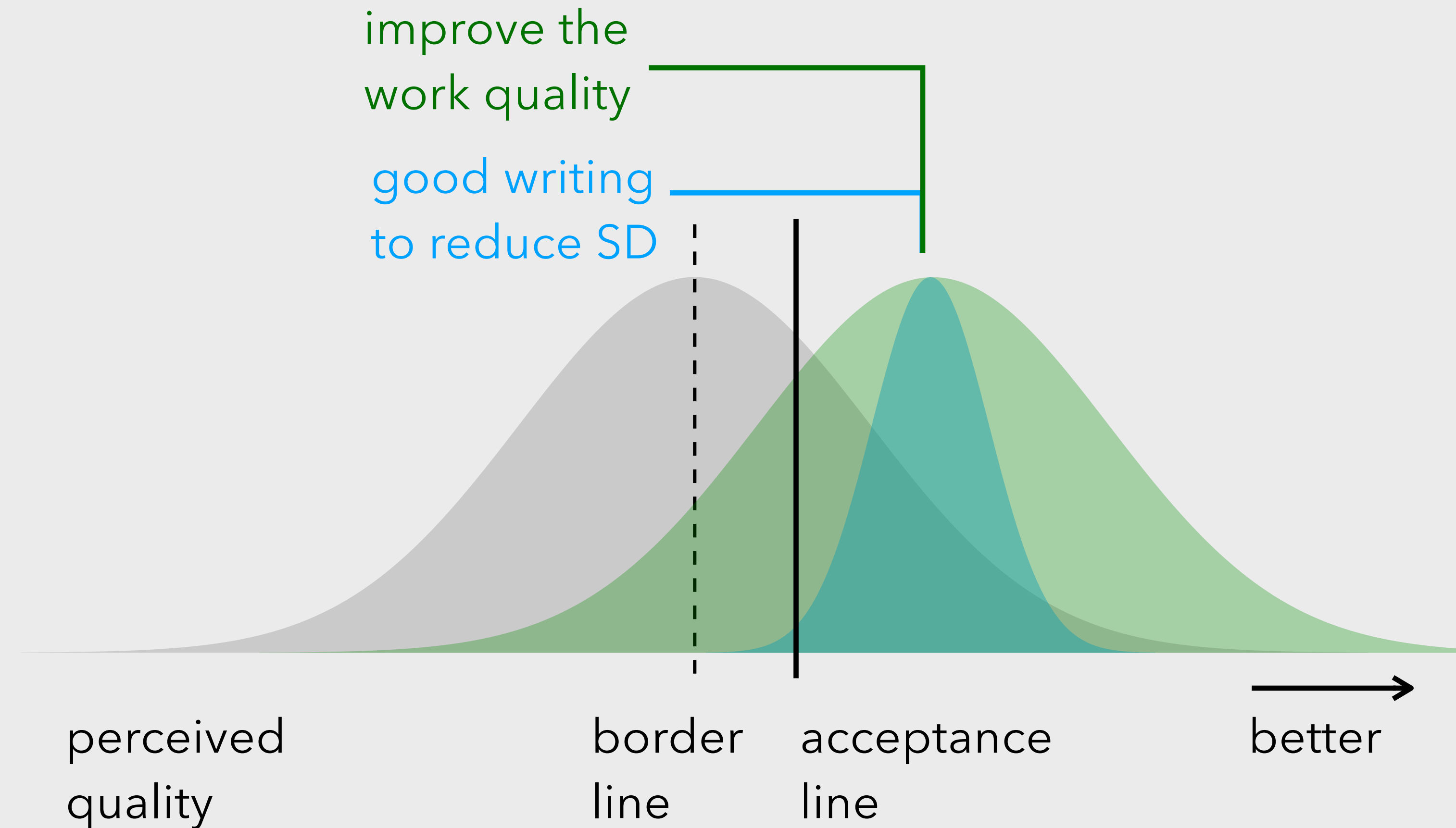
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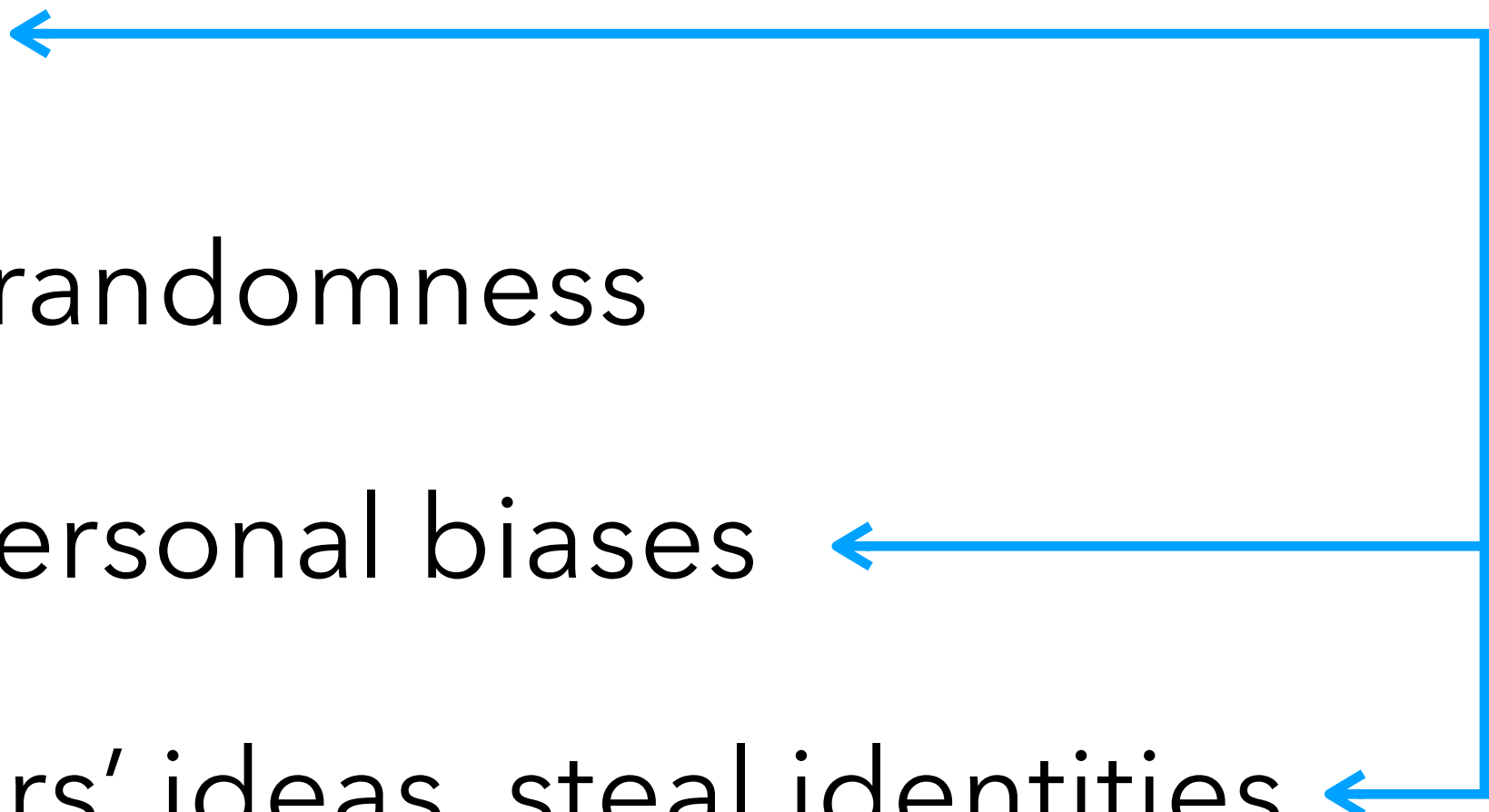
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Misconduct: reviewers steal authors' ideas, steal identities

As reviewers
I try to tell you
to avoid doing
these...



To be a good (enough) reviewer

Reviewer 2

Overly critical, expect perfection

Not constructive (so authors don't know what to do)

... Read the paper in a very different way than others do



Reviewer 2

Someone gives you a hard time,
could be R1, R3

The numbering is based on when
they submit their reviews

R1 - interested & managed

R3 - no time

R2 - between them



Reviewer 2

Personalities, randomness, ...

You can be a R2 sometimes, but you shouldn't be overly critical all the times

Sometimes, a short positive review isn't as useful as a long, constructive neutral review

Review template

Some journals/conferences give you a template, but most of the time, there is a field called "The review"

Summary A short description (1 sentence to 1 paragraph) of the work,
Identify the contributions

Strengths Identify good things about the paper

Weaknesses ... where you can be an R2

Review template

Summary

Strengths

Often it's hard to write positive points.

Sometimes it's hard to write positive points.

E.g., topic, impact, novel, approach, rigor, writing, figure

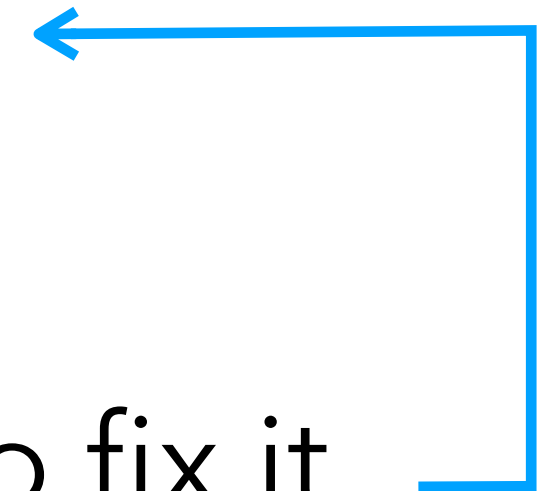
Weaknesses

Don't expect perfection. Ask, is this issue critical?

Is this fixable? – writing, or do a bit more work?

Contribution – sometimes, it is just reframing

Be constructive. Give authors a clue about how to fix it.



... also give authors some freedom

Review template

Summary

Strengths

Weaknesses

Organize your review

Avoid being “stream-of-consciousness”

Hard for PC/AC to distill/summarize your points

Hard for them to understand your attitude

Hard for authors, too

...although many reviews are alike that

How to review a paper

When I was a PhD student, I read the manuscript twice, and think it overnight. On the second day, I write the review, wait for another day to come back and edit it

Now, read it on the first day, write and edit on the same day or next

I write down **bullet points first**, then shuffle around and **organize** them, and **order** by severity: major issues, lesser issues, typos, etc.

Sometimes you should give a "required revisions" section

Our review assignment

I don't expect a review of 1,500 words from you

Each paper have 2-4 reviewers, each paper contributes the same number of reviews

Help you get a bite of this process

Questions?

Let's Talk about **Effective** Revisions

Why this process exists

This was a presentation at
a group meeting around two
years ago around this time...

QPR + final exam + presentation = a project cycle

CHI

Brainstorm & discussion

VIS

Do the work

CSCW

Analyze the data

Ubicomp

Submit an abstract

VR

Submit the paper

ISMAR (?)

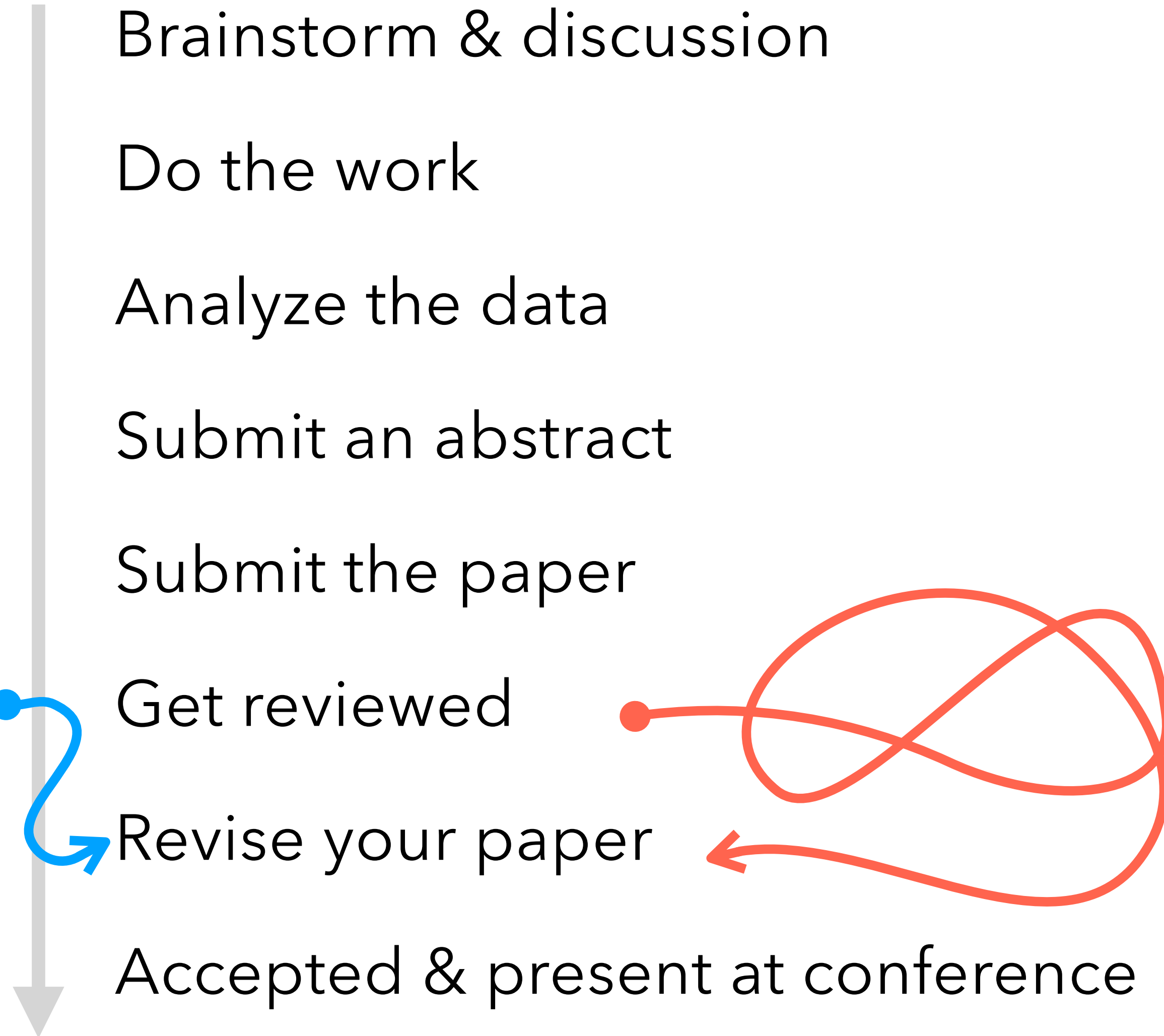
Get reviewed

Journal...

Revise your paper

Accepted & present at conference

Rejected



**It is a conversation
with the reviewers.**

**Conversation!
Conversation!
Conversation!**

Conversation

It is an opportunity to improve your paper and correct reviewers' mistakes.

Conference is faster than journal → but authors get angry at reviewers (mistakes/confusion/perfunctory) → SIGGRAPH started a rebuttal process to give authors a chance to talk to reviewers → but authors make promises and don't actually improve their papers

Conference is consistently changing. This is the fourth year for CHI's RR process. VIS has a longer record, but VIS's problem is that most reviewers don't get a chance to see the revisions.

IUI went from no rebuttal to rebuttal two years ago I believe...

CSCW and UbiComp have different models.

...

How to do it

A summary letter

Thank the reviewers.

R1, R2, & R3 pointed out blah.

We revised blah to address the comment. (A brief summary of what you changed + where to look for the changes).

...

Minor comments such as typos are addressed in place.

A point-for-point letter

Copy and paste every word.

You could be more detailed about your revisions and responses. Also see our response to R1 and meta-review above.

...

Thank the reviewers again.

Thank the reviewers

Reviewing is mostly volunteering work. Non-paid.

Takes hours to write a (good) review.

Once I was reviewing papers with a 102+F fever 🤒 (COVID)...

Fumeng: I'm not suggesting that you should do the same thing

What the reviewers/PC members want...

They want that you effectively and politely respond to their points.

Tell them where to look for your revisions in a paper stack!

In this sense, I believe a point-for-point letter is necessary, in addition to a revision summary.

What do you want when others respond to you in a conversation? Their points! People are open to some different opinions, but they hate people who are too defensive or too chatty.

If it is a group conversation, then they care about if you respond to their points. Fumeng: in early of my PhD, I also read the whole revised paper as well as authors responses to other reviewers' comments. Oh, no, I have a pile of papers to look at. Please help me quickly find the answers I want. If you go easy on me, I will also go easy on you.

Also, reviewers are alike you. They might have COVID, flu, fever, surgery, etc. while reviewing your paper because they have to fulfill their duties. Don't expect them to be perfect. They also make mistakes.

Some advisor may suggest starting with a google spreadsheet...

Fumeng: no you don't need that for CHI/VIS. It's a waste of your time.

Just start to prepare your revision letter on Day 1.

But if you are not gonna do two letters, you should have a spreadsheet...

PCs have summarized everything and ordered them for you. They even told you what are important. You don't need to redo all the work. If they miss anything, you can still capture it when preparing for your full letter. Having the full letter also gives you a context for their comments and makes sure you don't missing anything.

In rare cases, you might need to summarize them yourself. TVCG editors sometimes just say 'see reviews'. But you can still do this by preparing for a summary letter.

My advisor asked me to start with a write-up of **how I would address the comments. We then discussed to reach an **agreement** and then make the changes.**

Fumeng: At the very beginning, I meowed a lot. Now I realize this is an effective strategy.

For senior PhD students, you may just do a pass and mark things that you are not sure about. For junior PhD students, you may have a lot to discuss and your co-authors may have more experience with dealing with the reviews. So, yes, discussion prior to actual changes is effective.

Number each comment (e.g., R-1)

This will make it much easier to track changes and discuss them!

Can we look at R2-2, I don't know what this reviewer wants.

Can you read my responses to R1-2, R2-3, and R3-4...

What if I've said something in the paper but reviewers overlook it?

Very common. Just make a minimal change and point reviewers to that change. Say something like 'we highlight blah blah'.

You may miss something in your own paper. It is common for reviewers to miss something. Also, they miss it it means that you didn't highlight it enough...

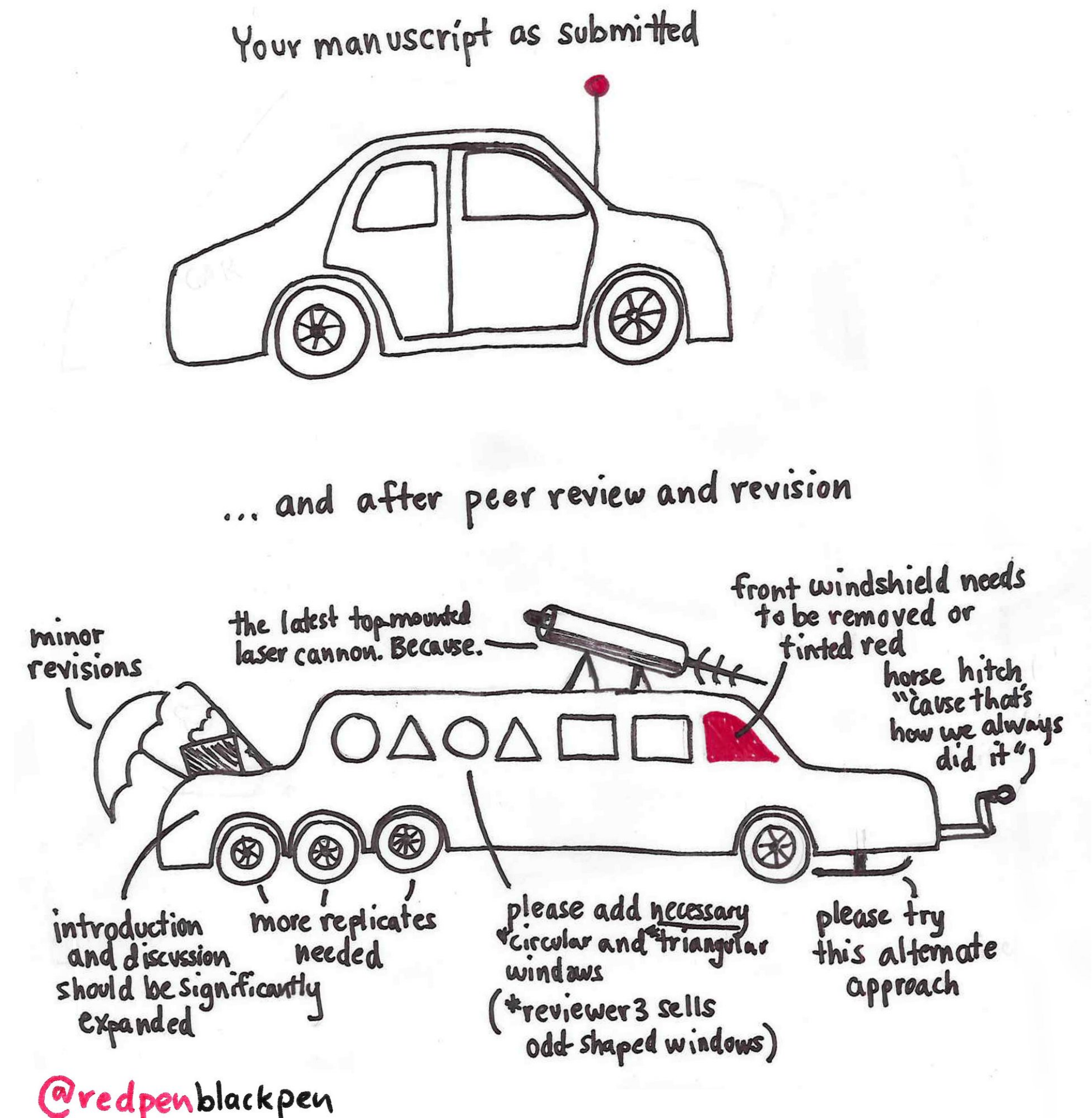
What if reviewers misunderstand something?

Very common. Clarify that. Say something like “we’d like to first clarify, ... and we revise ... to clarify this point.”

What if reviewers ask me to change something that I don't want to change?

It depends. If the reviewer is absolutely wrong, you should explain it. But make sure this happens ≤ 3 times in one review round.

Most of the time, I choose to follow the reviewers' suggestions (e.g. when they are right, and I don't have a strong preference...)



What if reviewers ask me to change something while I think there is a better way?

CHI24 explicitly instructed reviewers not to do this. But if it happens, you can briefly explain your reason – the common goal is to improve your paper. Say something like ‘we are inspired by [the reviewer’s point] ...’

Some people may think it is better to write down the way they want the authors to revise the paper.

Read your revisions and full paper again

Common mistakes

Revisions break the coherence of your paper

You change one place but forget the other place

...

Questions?

Examples

Bad Example 1

Not highlighting the changes!

Are you asking me to read the whole paper again?

I may find more reasons to reject your paper?

Highlight changes

LaTeX macro

```
% this is where we disable/enable edits
```

```
\newif\ifedited
```

```
\editedtrue % display edits
```

```
% \editedfalse % hide edits - no colors
```

```
\definecolor{editcolor}{HTML}{ff0000}
```

```
\newcommand{\edits}[1]
```

```
{\ifedited{\leavevmode\color{editcolor}{#1}}\else{#1}\fi}
```


Highlight changes

I don't like the auto highlighting, very distracting

~~Another~~ Yet another section title

~~A paragraph with a line only in the draft document.~~ More things could be said were it not for the constraints of time and space.

A paragraph with a line only in the revised document. More things could be said were it not for the constraints of time and space.

And here is a ~~tip~~otypo.

Here is a table:

Name	Description
Gandalf	Grey <u>White</u>
Saruman	White <u>Evil</u>

And ~~sometimes a whole paragraph gets completely rewritten. In this case latexdiff marks up the whole paragraph even if some words in it are identical~~ now for something completely different, with not a paragraph in sight. No change, no markup!

Bad-ish example 3

If you are too detailed and long in your response, it could also hurt you.

Usually, a response does not need to be substantially longer than a comment. It is a conversation.

If you have to do this, try to be more effective – say your actual responses first and then state your reasons (because otherwise, it reads too defensive...)

For the final exam

Reasonable responses

We are not try to accept or reject your paper

But want you to improve your paper within the amount of time

Discuss with your coauthors, choose a 1-page summary or a point-for-point letter (or both?). Whichever is more reasonable for you.

Highlighting: please do that.

Questions?